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Shortest Cable Routing of Heliostats in Solar Tower Power Plants

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1 Introduction

In this work we present two heuristics that compute valid solutions to an optimization problem regarding a cabling problem in solar tower power plants. Such a plant focuses sunlight with the help of heliostats onto a receiver that is installed at the top of the solar tower. This energy heats up a medium like oil or sodium in order to power a turbine which generates electric energy in return. Such a plant consists of a solar tower and heliostats that have to be connected to the solar tower with two types of cables, namely a power and data cable. Both cables are needed at each heliostat as the sun's position has to be taken into account for an efficient exploitation of solar energy. Regarding the cabling we have several limitations with respect to connectivity and planarity constraints. First, cables have restrictions regarding their maximum lengths between heliostats. Moreover, there are capacity constraints for each cable, namely that cables can only connect so many heliostats. Second, the planarity constraint is enforced in order to have a low maintenance cost when digging up trenches.

Another source of energy is utilized in offshore wind farms for which the cabling problem has been studied in [5, 2, 4]. The same constraints like planarity are also present in their cabling problem. Our work builds up on two bachelor's theses that studied the solar tower power plants [6, 10].

In the following we will give a formal definition of our problem and present two heuristics that apply the local search optimization method [1, 11]. This approach was chosen due to the high complexity of the cabling problem, which is especially difficult to solve for large instances that inhibit a lot of heliostats. Then, an evaluation part is followed where we have applied both heuristics onto the PS10 solar tower power plant [7, 8]. Afterwards we give a short summary and possible future work.

2 Problem statement

Formally, we are given an undirected graph $G = (V, E)$ where $V = \{T\} \cup V_H$ with T being our solar tower and $V_H := \{v_1, \dots, v_n\}$ denotes the set of heliostats. Note that we work in a metric space $(\mathbb{R}^2, d)$, thus we denote with $v_x \in \mathbb{R}$ and $v_y \in \mathbb{R}$ both coordinates for each vertex $v \in V$. Moreover, the metric is simply the euclidean distance

$$d(v, w) := \sqrt{(v_x - w_x)^2 + (v_y - w_y)^2}$$

between nodes $v, w \in V$. In other words, each vertex $v \in V$ has a specified position in a 2D plane.

Before a cable can be installed a trench has to be constructed by workers for which we have to pay installation costs. Let us denote these costs per meter with $c^{\text{trench}} \in \mathbb{R}^+$. In other words, the total costs of providing a trench between $v, w \in V$ is $c_{vw}^{\text{trench}} := d(v, w) \cdot c^{\text{trench}}$.

2.1 Data cable and local control units

We can install different types of cables which have length and connection restrictions depending on its type. For this matter let D be the set of data cables with costs $c_d^{\text{data}} \in \mathbb{R}^+$ per meter for each cable $d \in D$. We further define for readability the costs $c_{d,vw}^{\text{data}} := d(v, w) \cdot c_d^{\text{data}}$ of installing a cable of type d on the edge $vw \in E$. Furthermore, each data cable $d \in D$ has a length restriction $L_d^{\text{data}} \in \mathbb{R}^+$ and a restriction on how many heliostats it can connect to, that is, $M_d^{\text{data}} \in \mathbb{N}$ for $d \in D$.

Aside from the cables we have to build *local control units* (LCU) at each heliostat. These LCUs are used for communication processing and may allow branching by e.g. installing an 8- or 16-port LCU at an heliostat. Each of these LCU has connectivity-restrictions for each cable type $d \in D$. For this matter, let S the set of all LCUs where each $s \in S$ has installation costs $c_s^{\text{lcu}} \in \mathbb{R}^+$. The connectivity or vertex-degree restrictions are given by $l_{s,d}, u_{s,d} \in \mathbb{N}$ for each LCU $s \in S$ and cable type $d \in D$. Both restrictions state that the LCU $s \in S$ has to connect at least $l_{s,d}$ cables of type $d \in D$, whereas $u_{s,d}$ is the upper bound of incident cables of type $d \in D$ at an heliosat that installed LCU $s \in S$.

2.2 Power cables

► [formal definition]

2.3 Cabling problem

Problem 1 (Cabling Problem) *Given a complete, undirected graph $G = (V, E)$.*

► [capacity constraint]

3 Data

We present real world data regarding costs per meter for various data as well as power cables. Moreover, many different LCUs and trench/installation costs are provided for which we can test our heuristics on. The experiments are running on the PS10 solar tpower power plant instance [7, 8] for which the coordinates are provided, a sketch of this instance can be seen in fig. 1.

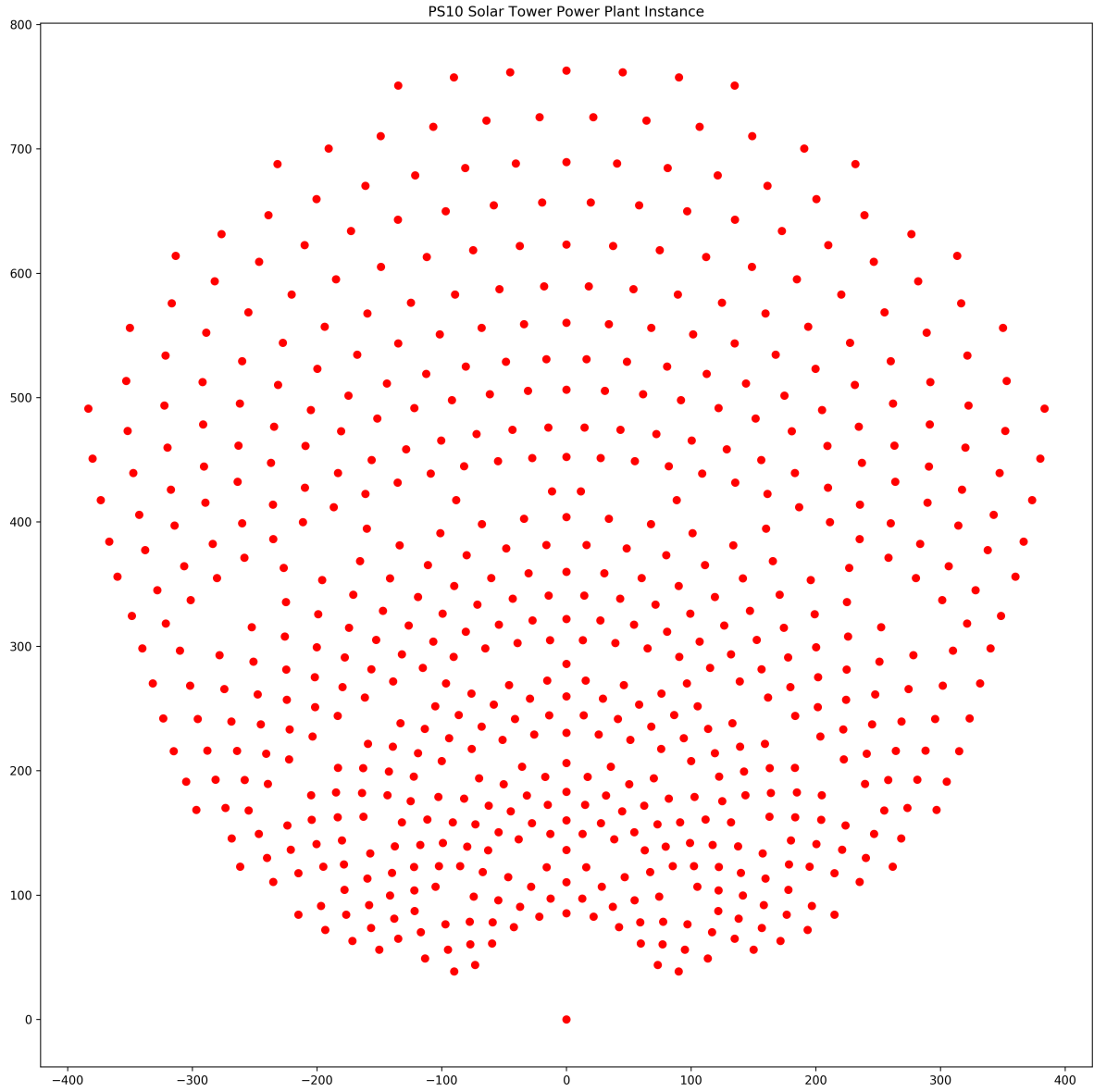


Figure 1: PS10 instance with its heliostats and the solar tower at coordinate $(0,0)$.

3.1 Trench costs

For the trench costs we are considering four different costs, each depending on the country we are located in. Each trench has to be constructed by workers and has a depth of 1m as well as 1m in width and length.

Table 1: Trench costs for different countries

Country	Costs [€/m]
Australia	50
Spain	25
South Africa	10
United Arab Emirates	10

3.2 Data Cable

Regarding the data cable we are able to install either a copper or fiberglass cable. The copper cable is much cheaper however it has harsh restrictions regarding its usage, making it only usable for endpoint connections. The fiberglass on the other hand can connect an arbitrary amount of heliostats and has no length restrictions.

Table 2: Possible data cables with their cost and restrictions.

Data cable type	Max. capacity	Max. length [m]	Price [€/m]
Copper	2	100	0.7
Fiberglass	∞	∞	2

3.2.1 Local Control Units

Exactly one local control units is installed at every heliostat so that communication is enabled. All LCUs with the exception of an endpoint has exactly one ingoing fiberglass cable. The endpoint has exactly one ingoing copper cable.

Table 3: Local control units with their degree and cable restrictions for both cable types.

LCU type s	Price [€/piece]	Copper		Fiberglass	
		$l_{s,\text{COPPER}}$	$u_{s,\text{COPPER}}$	$l_{s,\text{FIBER}}$	$u_{s,\text{FIBER}}$
Endpoint	10	1	1	0	0
Conductor	100	0	0	1	2
8-port copper	800	0	7	1	2
8-port fiberglass	800	0	0	1	9
16-port copper	1500	0	15	1	2
16-port fiberglass	1500	0	0	1	17

Therefore, an 8-port copper LCU for example has up to 7 'outgoing' copper connections and up to one 'outgoing' fiberglass one.

3.3 Power Cable

The power cables are not restricted with LCUs. However, maximum capacity constraints have to be taken into account — as opposed to glasfiber cables that do not have any capacity restrictions. Hence, we have to use more than one power cable for instances with more than 250 heliostats. Therefore we have to partition the heliostats field into partitions that is non-trivial. A simple heuristic is presented in section 4.1.

Table 4: Power cables with their connectivity limitations and prices.

Power cable type	Max. capacity	Max. length [m]	Price [€/m]
NYY-J 3x2.5 RE	56	38.36	0.58
NYY-J 3x4 RE	73	47.08	0.87
NYY-J 3x6 RE	92	56.04	1.24
NYY-J 3x10 RE	124	69.30	1.95
NYY-J 3x16 RE	162	84.87	3.13
NYY-J 3x25 RM	209	102.79	5.19
NYY-J 3x35 RM	250	120.31	6.90

4 Heuristics

In the following both sections we present our heuristics that are based on the local-search optimization method [1, 11]. The basic structure of such an algorithm is shown in algorithm 1. Basically we first compute an initial solution from the input and afterwards improve it stepwise until some stopping criterion is met. In principle the stepwise improvements are performed locally to *sol* such that each step yields a valid solution to our optimization problem.

Algorithm 1 A general framework of a local search heuristic.

```
1: procedure LOCAL-SEARCH(input)
2:   init := COMPUTE-INITIAL-SOLUTION(input)
3:   sol := init
4:   while stopping criterion not met do
5:     x := COMPUTE-NEXT-NEIGHBOR-SOLUTION(sol)
6:     if  $c(x) < c(sol)$  then
7:       sol := x
8:     end if
9:   end while
10:  return sol
11: end procedure
```

One may interpret this by jumping from one point in the valid solution search space to another one in a certain local neighborhood. This interpretation is depicted in fig. 2 where s_0 is the initial solution that we improve in a stepwise-manner by selecting a neighboring solution s_1 in its neighborhood $N(s_0)$. Obviously s_1 has lower total costs than s_2 , however, depending on the neighborhood size $|N(s_0)|$ it may be a computationally demanding task. Therefore, while generating the neighboring solutions in $N(s_0)$ we terminate the search process as soon as we encounter a solution $s_1 \in N(s_0)$ with $c(s_1) < c(s_0)$. This search strategy is called *first-improvement* as we do not generate the best neighboring solution but are satisfied with any kind of improvement. This process is then continued until some stopping criterion is met. In particular, one may terminate after $i \in \mathbb{N}$ steps or in our case terminate as soon as $N(s_i)$ does not yield any improving solution, hence s_i is called *locally optimal*.

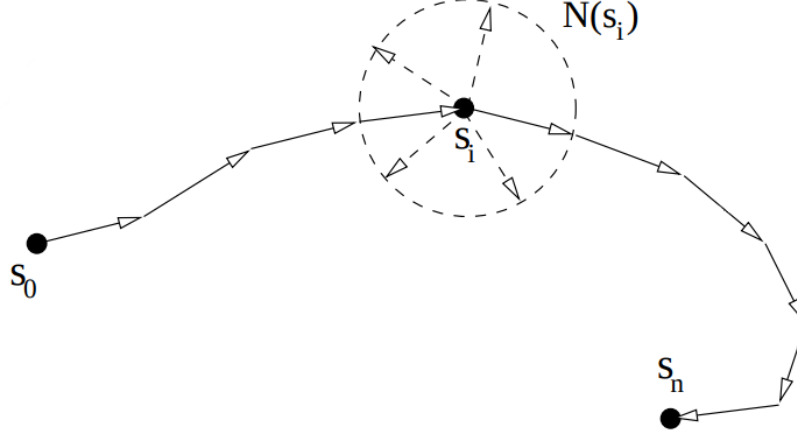


Figure 2: The search space where each point describes a valid solution to our optimization problem. We start from the initial solution s_0 improve it stepwise. For this matter we consider 'neighboring' solutions in $N(s_i)$ at the current solution s_i . When no neighboring solution is improving (i.e. has less total costs than current solution) we terminate our algorithm as s_n is a locally optimal solution.

4.1 Partitioning

Because the largest power cable has a capacity of 250 heliostats and instances like the PS10 have more heliostats we have to use more than one power cable in order to connect all heliostats, hence a partitioning of the heliostats has to be considered additionally. We perform a simple heuristic for this problem by computing the angles α_h between the reference vector $(1, 0)^T$ and an heliostat $h \in V_H$ like in fig. 3. Afterwards, the partitioning is the result of sorting the angles. All in all, this procedure has a time complexity of $\mathcal{O}(|V_H|^2 \log(|V_H|))$.

We can compute initial solutions for the local search procedure independently on each partition, therefore obtaining $k \in \mathbb{N}$ initial solutions for k partitions.

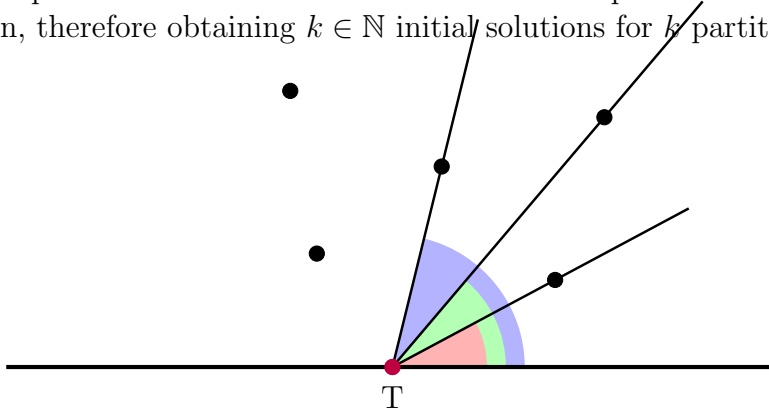


Figure 3: Sort heliostats by computed angles. For $k \in \mathbb{N}$ partitions we obtain $\left\lceil \frac{|V_H|}{k} \right\rceil$ heliostats in each partition.

Because this heuristic is a hard assignment of the heliostats to their respective partition we have to consider exchange-operations in the local search algorithms so that non-convex partitions are able to arise. Otherwise we limit ourselves to the hard-assignments and local search solutions are poor with regards to their quality.

4.2 Greedy Power Cable Assignment

4.3 Minimum Spanning Tree Approach

The fact that each heliostat has to be connected to the solar tower T with minimal costs infers utilizing a minimum spanning tree approach. We just need to consider the additional constraints of planarity as well as connectivity constraints. We thus choose Prim's algorithm [9, 3] to compute an initial, valid solution to our problem. Afterwards we compute a greedy power cable assignment which yields a valid solution to section 2.3.

For the local search improvement steps we choose the *cycle-neighborhood*

$$N(T) := \{\tilde{T} \in \mathcal{T} \mid c(\tilde{T}) < c(T) \wedge |E(\tilde{T}) \setminus E(T)| = 1\}$$

for a spanning tree $T \subset G$ and $\mathcal{T}$ denotes the set of all spanning trees in G .

For an update step we thus delete an edge $e \in E(T)$ in our current tree T and reconnect the disconnected partition by a new edge $f \in E \setminus (E(T) \cup \{e\})$ which yields $\tilde{T}$. By doing this we effectively move from T to another spanning tree $\tilde{T}$. In order to improve our current solution we always choose an edge f with $c(f) < c(e)$. If no such edge exists, we can terminate the local search procedure as the neighborhood $N(T)$ is empty, hence T is a locally optimal solution. Such an update step is sketched in fig. 4.

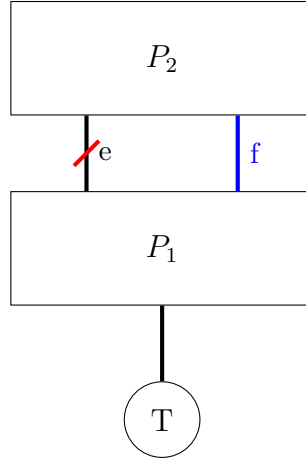


Figure 4: Consider the cycle neighborhood $N(T)$, that is, delete edge e and reconnect the resulting partitions P_1 and P_2 by adding an edge f with $c(f) < c(e)$.

Mor ► [\[Upgrade-Downgrade\]](#)

4.4 Hamiltonian Path Approach

If every heliostat is incident to maximal two cable connections we are able to use Conductors only, which reduces the amount of switch costs we are installing (see table 2). Therefore we consider a Hamiltonian path as a basis for the second heuristic.

4.4.1 Initial Solution

The initial solution is built greedily by starting from the solar tower T and extending the hamiltonian path step by step. For this matter we consider a *partial path* of vertices of length $i \in \mathbb{N}$, that is, $p = (v_0, v_1, v_2, \dots, v_i)$, for heliostats $v_j \in V_H$, $1 \leq j \leq i \leq |V_H|$, $v_0 := T$. For arbitrary partial paths we define the distance as the sum of euclidean distances, that is

$$Dist((v_0, v_1, v_2, \dots, v_i)) := \sum_{k=0}^{i-1} d(v_k, v_{k+1})$$

Given a partial path $p = (v_0, v_1, \dots, v_i)$, $0 \leq i \leq |V_H|$ we additionally introduce the *extended path* for an unvisited heliostat $v \in V_H \setminus V(p)$ that is placed after the m -th vertex in the partial path p :

$$ExtPath(p, v, m) := (v_0, v_1, \dots, v_m, v, v_{m+1}, \dots, v_i)$$

for $1 \leq m \leq i$. In other words we may append a heliostat at the end of p or insert it into the path directly, effectively adding edges $\{v_{m-1}, v\}$, $\{v, v_{m+1}\}$ and deleting the existing edge $\{v_{m-1}, v_{m+1}\}$.

Therefore, given a partial path $p = (v_0, v_1, \dots, v_i)$ we can extend it by computing the minimal distance of all possible extended paths, in other words

$$\forall m \in \{1, \dots, i\} \forall v \in V_H \setminus V(p) : \min \{Dist(ExtPath(p, v, m))\}$$

This search procedure can be computed in $\mathcal{O}(|V_H|^2)$ time in each step until all heliostat are visited. Note that we do not need to check intersections of edges for the partial paths because the initial solutions are computed independently for each partition and form a convex polygon. Further we only consider euclidean distances as opposed to the initial minimum spanning tree solution in section 4.3 because installations of LCUs were included in edge costs.

Algorithm 2 Greedy construction of a hamiltonian path.

```
1: procedure INIT-HAMILTON( $G = (V, E)$ )
2:    $p := (T)$ 
3:   while  $|p| < |V_H|$  do
4:     for  $m = 1, \dots, i$  do
5:       for  $v \in V_H \setminus V(p)$  do
6:         compute  $Dist(ExtPath(p, v, m))$ 
7:       end for
8:     end for
9:      $p^* := \min\{Dist(ExtPath(p, ))\}$ 
10:  end while
11: end procedure
```

5 Evaluation

► [Evaluation tables and so on]

6 Conclusion

► [Conclusion]

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